

FREE GUIDE

The SMB Social Media Starter Kit

A no-fluff guide to setting up, running and growing your brand's social media from scratch

Who this is for

You run a business. You know social media matters. You don't have a marketing team, a content calendar, or three hours a day to figure this out. This guide is the version of "how to do social media" we'd actually hand a friend who just opened a shop, a studio, or a service business — no jargon, no fluff, just the steps in order.

Step 1 — Pick your platforms, not all of them

The biggest mistake small businesses make is trying to be everywhere at once. Two platforms, done consistently, will always beat five platforms done half-heartedly.

- **Instagram** — almost always the right starting point in India, for nearly any consumer-facing business. Visual, discovery-friendly, and where most of your customers already are.
- **WhatsApp** — not glamorous, but for SMBs it's often the highest-converting channel you have. A Business catalog and a broadcast list matter more than people give them credit for.
- **Google Business Profile** — not "social media" in the traditional sense, but it's free, it's where people check you're real, and it directly drives local search and maps visibility.
- **LinkedIn** — only if you sell to businesses, not consumers.
- **YouTube / Facebook** — add these later, once your first two channels have a rhythm. Don't start here.

Pick two. Ignore the rest until the first two feel easy.

Step 2 — Set up a profile that actually converts

A follower who lands on your profile decides whether to trust you in about three seconds. Get these right before you post a single thing:

- **Profile photo** — your logo, cropped tight, readable at thumbnail size.
 - **Name field** — include what you actually do, not just your brand name (e.g. "Studio Verve | Custom Furniture, Chennai").
 - **Bio** — three lines, max. What you do, who it's for, and one reason to trust you (years in business, number of clients, a credential).
 - **Link** — one clear link. If you don't have a website yet, link your WhatsApp catalog or a Linktree. Never leave this blank.
 - **Highlights / pinned content** — this is your homepage. At minimum: an "About" highlight, a "Reviews" highlight, and a "How to Order/Book" highlight.
 - **Contact buttons** — turn on WhatsApp, email, and directions (if you have a physical location) in your business settings.
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Step 3 — Define your content pillars

A content pillar is just a repeatable *category* of post. Having 3–5 of these means you never stare at a blank screen wondering what to post — you just work through your pillars on rotation.

A good starting set for most SMBs:

1. **Product/Service spotlight** — what you sell, shown clearly and well.
2. **Behind-the-scenes** — how it's made, who makes it, the process.
3. **Social proof** — reviews, testimonials, customer results, repost of tagged content.
4. **Education** — a tip, a mistake to avoid, a "did you know."
5. **Offer/Promo** — the direct sell. Keep this to roughly 1 in every 5–7 posts — too much and your feed becomes an ad.

Write your 3–5 pillars down. Every time you don't know what to post, pick the pillar you've used least recently.

Step 4 — Build a simple posting rhythm

Consistency beats frequency. A brand that posts 3 times a week, every week, for six months will outperform a brand that posts daily for two weeks and then disappears.

A realistic starting cadence:

- **Instagram feed/Reels:** 3–4 times a week
- **Instagram Stories:** most days you're open/active — these are low-effort and keep you top-of-mind
- **WhatsApp broadcast:** once a week, max twice — respect the channel
- **Google Business Profile posts/photos:** once a week

Pick a rhythm you can actually sustain for three months without help. A smaller, sustainable rhythm beats an ambitious one you abandon by week three.

Step 5 — The content creation loop

Don't create content one post at a time — batch it. A simple weekly or biweekly loop:

1. **Plan** — 15 minutes, pick which pillar each upcoming post covers.
 2. **Shoot** — set aside one block of time to shoot everything for the week/fortnight in one go. Natural light, a clean background, and a phone camera are enough to start.
 3. **Edit** — keep it simple. Consistent filters/colors, readable captions if you add text on-screen, and trim anything that drags.
 4. **Write captions** — draft all captions in one sitting, right after shooting, while the context is fresh.
 5. **Schedule** — use Meta Business Suite (free) or any scheduler to queue the week/fortnight in advance, so posting doesn't depend on remembering every single day.
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Step 6 — Community management basics

Posting is half the job — showing up in the comments and DMs is the other half, and it's where trust and sales actually happen.

- Reply to every comment, even a simple "thank you 🙌" — it signals an active account to both people and the algorithm.
- Respond to DMs within a few hours during business hours where possible. Slow replies lose warm leads.
- Engage with your own community *before* you post — a few minutes commenting on customers' or local accounts' posts, especially right before you publish.

- Save your most common questions ("what are your prices," "do you deliver," "what are your hours") as quick-reply templates so you can respond fast without retyping every time.
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Step 7 — The 5 numbers that actually matter

Ignore likes as your main metric — they're the easiest number to inflate and the least connected to revenue. Track these instead:

1. **Reach** — how many people actually saw the post (are you growing your audience, or just talking to the same small group?)
2. **Saves** — the strongest signal that content was genuinely useful or desirable enough to come back to.
3. **Shares** — the strongest signal of "I want someone else to see this," which is how new audiences find you organically.
4. **Profile visits from a post** — tells you the content made someone curious enough to check who you are.
5. **Follows generated by a specific post** — the clearest link between a piece of content and actual growth.

Check these weekly. Whichever *pillar* consistently produces your best numbers on these five — do more of that.

Your 30-Day Starter Checklist

Week 1 — Foundation

- ☐ Choose your two starting platforms
- ☐ Fix your profile photo, bio, link, and highlights
- ☐ Turn on contact buttons (WhatsApp/email/directions)
- ☐ Write down your 3–5 content pillars

Week 2 — First batch

- ☐ Block 2 hours to shoot content for the next two weeks
- ☐ Write all captions for that content in one sitting
- ☐ Schedule the first week of posts
- ☐ Post your first "About us" style intro if you haven't already

Week 3 — Rhythm

- ☐ Post consistently on your chosen cadence
- ☐ Reply to every comment and DM within the day
- ☐ Send your first WhatsApp broadcast
- ☐ Note which post got the most saves/shares

Week 4 — Review

- ☐ Check your 5 key numbers across the month
 - ☐ Identify your best-performing pillar
 - ☐ Plan next month's content leaning into what worked
 - ☐ Ask 3 happy customers for a review or a tagged post you can repost
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What's next

Once this rhythm feels easy — not perfect, just *easy* — that's your signal to add a third platform, start testing paid ads, or bring in a team to scale what's already working. Don't add complexity before the basics are boring to you. Boring and consistent is what builds a brand.